

Dvar Torah Outline — Parashat Ha'azinu / Shabbat Shuvah: Reverence for Shem Hashem, Proper Kedushah-Order, and Yom Kippur's Limits (Rabbi Shulman)

Abstract

Rabbi Shulman, drawing on the Maharal and Sifrei, develops how Moshe Rabbeinu models profound awe before uttering Shem Hashem, learning from the angels' "קדוש קדוש קדוש" and expanding it with a 21-word preface before "כי שם ה' אקרא." He then traces a progression of halachic and ethical demands: not placing Hashem's Name "in midair," responding with added praise when hearing His Name (e.g., in Barchu), and appreciating the spiritual advantage of the one who answers "אמן." Finally, Rabbi Shulman applies a Gemara in Shevuot to Yom Kippur, explaining why certain sins undermine the very relationship that Yom Kippur is meant to restore—and warns that casual mention of Hashem's Name can fall into that category.

I. Moshe Rabbeinu's 21-word introduction before mentioning Shem Hashem

A. The Maharal's opening: a "lengthy" preface in Ha'azinu

- Rabbi Shulman notes that Moshe Rabbeinu begins with an extended introduction—**21 words**—before first mentioning Hashem explicitly.

- Key verse:

◦ "כי שם ה' אקרא הבו גדל לאלקינו" ("When I call out the Name of Hashem, ascribe greatness to our God.")

B. Sifrei: why not start with Shem Hashem immediately?

- The Sifrei is bothered: if Moshe is giving a major address, why delay Shem Hashem?
- Answer (Tanna Kamma): Moshe learned this derech erez from מלאכי השרת.

C. The angels' model: "קדוש קדוש קדוש" before "ה' צבאות"

- Angels first proclaim "קדוש קדוש קדוש", and only then say "ה' צבאות."

- Rabbi Shulman explains (via Maharal):
 - קדוש means מובדל—Hashem is utterly separate/transcendent.
 - The threefold קדוש signals layered transcendence: beyond what we know and experience.
 - Maharal's framing: Hashem is למעלה מן הזמן, encompassing היה הוה ויהיה.

D. A contemporary mussar application: not “throwing” Shem Shamayim from the mouth

- Rabbi Shulman critiques casual speech around berachot and Hashem's Name (especially approaching Yom Kippur):
 - Saying Hashem's Name hastily, while already eating, is framed as a ביזיון to Shem Hashem.
 - The takeaway: if angels require preparation, certainly people must approach uttering Hashem's Name with reverence and readiness.

E. Why Moshe's preface is 21 (seven times the angels' three)

- Moshe reasons: if angels need three קדוש, he should do **sevenfold**.
- Rabbi Shulman explains Maharal's “seven”:
 - Angels endure for the world's duration (framed as **7,000 years**).
 - Man (after the sin) is fundamentally “sh״י” to **1,000 years** (Adam's original lifespan concept).
 - Thus, man is **one-seventh** relative to the angelic frame, so Moshe multiplies three by seven → **21**.

II. Proper ordering: not placing Hashem's Name before the kedushah-object exists (5:30)

A. Rabbi Shimon bar Yochai: even in a mitzvah context, order matters

- Rabbi Shulman cites the Midrash: you cannot speak of dedicating a korban in a way that leaves Hashem's Name “standing alone” even momentarily.
- The contrast:
 - Not: “להשם עולה”, “להשם נדבה”
 - Rather: “עולה להשם”, “נדבה להשם”

B. Concept: Shem Hashem should not be “hanging there” without a vessel

- Rabbi Shulman explains the logic:
 - If one says “להשם...” first, then for a split second Hashem’s Name is uttered without yet being attached to a sanctified act/object.
 - The Midrashic language quoted:
 - “אל יחל שמי עליהם עד שיקדישו” (“Let My Name not rest upon them until they have sanctified [it].”)
 - Core message: Shem Hashem should enter **בבת אחת**—together with the act of הקדשה.
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III. Hearing Shem Hashem obligates a response—and an added response (7:31)

A. Rabbi Yosi: obligation to answer when Hashem’s Name is proclaimed

- If one hears a ציבור proclamation containing Shem Hashem, one must respond.

B. Example: Barchu and the mandated addition

- When the chazzan says: “ברכו את ה' המבורך”, the ציבור answers:
 - “ברוך ה' המבורך לעולם ועד”
- Rabbi Shulman emphasizes: it’s not only answering—it’s **being מוסיף**, adding further praise.

C. Why add?

- Rabbi Shulman’s explanation:
 - If you merely “match” what was said, it suggests you weren’t elevated by hearing Shem Hashem.
 - The one who heard the Name gains a new privilege and responsibility: to rise and respond with greater kavod.

D. Moshe’s instruction embedded in the verse

- Rabbi Shulman ties this back to Ha'azinu:
 - “כי שם ה' אקרא הבו גדל לאלקינו”
 - When Moshe calls Shem Hashem, the listeners must “give greatness”—i.e., respond.
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IV. “Greater is the one who answers Amen” as a principle of spiritual strengthening (9:00)

A. Rabbi Nehorai: derech eretz from battle strategy

- Rabbi Shulman cites Rabbi Nehorai's analogy:
 - In war, the weaker forces engage first; the strong come afterward and clinch victory.
- So too: the responder comes after hearing the berachah and can respond with greater force.

B. “גדול העונה אמן מן המברך”

- Rabbi Shulman explains:
 - The responder has already been impacted by hearing Shem Hashem and the content of the berachah.
 - This produces added **חיוק** in אמונה and דביקות, enabling a more powerful response:
 - “אמן, קל מלך נאמן.”
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V. Yom Kippur is not mechaper for sins that negate the relationship itself (10:00)

A. Maharal brings a Gemara in Shevuot (י"ג ע"א): three עבירות

- Rabbi Shulman lists the three categories for which **Yom Kippur is not מכפר**:
 1. **מפר בבריתו של אברהם אבינו / כופר** (denying or violating the covenant of Avraham)
 2. **מגלה פנים בתורה** (denying the sanctity/greatness of Torah, written or oral)
 3. **פורק עול** (throwing off the yoke of Heaven)

B. Why these three? Yom Kippur repairs within a relationship—if one exists

- Rabbi Shulman explains Maharal's model:
 - Yom Kippur functions like immersion in a mikveh of closeness to Hashem (echoing Rabbi Akiva's “מקוה ישראל ה'” idea).
 - But cleansing presumes a living relationship, which needs:
 1. Hashem
 2. האדם
 3. The connecting bridge: **תורה**

- Each of the three עבירות removes one pillar:
 - פורק עול removes acknowledgement of Hashem as King.
 - מגלה פנים בתורה cuts the connection/bridge (Torah).
 - מפר בברית undermines the identity of the האדם who stands in covenant.

C. Torah Shebe'al Peh includes respect for its transmitters

- Rabbi Shulman adds (citing Rambam):
 - Denying Torah Shebe'al Peh includes מכחיש את מגידיה—disrespecting or rejecting the sages who transmit Torah.

VI. A warning: mentioning Hashem's Name casually can be "פורק עול" (12:30)

A. Maharal's inclusion: שמ שמים בחנם

- Rabbi Shulman states that the Maharal includes one who mentions Hashem's Name unnecessarily—מזכיר שמו בחנם—within the category of פורק עול.

B. Consequence: Yom Kippur not mechaper in that frame

- The implication is severe: if it reflects throwing off Heaven's yoke, it is not within the automatic kapparah mechanism of Yom Kippur.

C. Closing encouragement toward repair

- Rabbi Shulman clarifies the practical goal:
 - Strengthen reverence for Shem Hashem,
 - strengthen the חשיבות of Torah,
 - and strengthen self-identity as someone essentially bound in relationship with Hashem.
- Concludes with a brachah for גמר חתימה טובה and kapparah for all of Israel.

VII. In Summary

- Rabbi Shulman, based on Maharal and Sifrei, shows that Moshe Rabbeinu's 21-word preface to Shem Hashem models the reverence learned from the angels' "קדוש קדוש קדוש."
- Halachically and ethically, one must avoid placing Hashem's Name "in midair," instead attaching it only when the act/object is already קדוש (e.g., "עולה להשם").

- Hearing Shem Hashem obligates an elevated response—adding praise in Barchu and recognizing that “גדול העונה אמן מן המברך.”
- Yom Kippur's kapparah works within an intact relationship (Hashem—man—Torah); sins that deny one of these foundations (including casual, needless mention of Shem Hashem as “פורק עול”) block that kapparah and demand focused teshuvah.